

Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام

Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام in the Qur'ān

In the Qur'ān Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام is mentioned in four Surah: Surah Al-Imraan, Surah An'aam, Surah Maryam and Surah Ambiyaa. Of these in Surah An'aam his name is only mentioned as being one of the prophets whereas in the other three places he is mentioned and a little of his life-history is also mentioned.

However the Zakariya عليه السلام mentioned in the Qur'ān is not the same as the one mentioned in the Tauriat.

The Life History

1. Regarding his life history in detail very little is known about him, but from the Qur'ān and reliable historical reports the following is known:

Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام was a very pious preacher among Bani Israel and a well-known prophet of Allah. The Qur'ān counts him among the list of the prophets. It says:

"And Zakariya عليه السلام, and Yahya عليه السلام, and Esa عليه السلام and Ilyas عليه السلام all of them were of the righteous ones."

(6:85)

2. In previous pages it was mentioned that all the prophets, whether they were kings or rulers, all used to earn their livelihood by their own hands and none of them were a burden upon the shoulders of others. Thus when any *Nabi* called his people towards guidance, he said to them:

"I do not ask of you any reward for conveying this message. My reward is only from Allah."

Hence Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام used to earn his livelihood from carpentry as is mentioned in the *Hadith*:

3. In the family of Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام there was someone called Imran bin Naushi and his wife Hanna. They were two very pious people but had no children. In answer to the prayer of Hanna a girl was born to her whose name was given Mariyam and according to an oath sworn by her, Hanna the child was offered for the service of the place of worship. There was some difference of opinion regarding who was to take care of Mariyam. Hence lots were cast and in this manner, the lot went to the name of Zakariya عليه السلام,

Qur'ān says:

"To the Cave of Zakariya was she assigned."

(3:37)

When Mariyam reached her age of understanding, Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام arranged for her a private chamber near the place of worship where she could in her own privacy remain busy with meditation and worship and from there she could go to spend the nights with her aunt, Hazrat Zakariya (*Alaihis Salām*)'s wife.

The Qur'ān states:

"Every time that he [Zakariya ﷺ] entered her chamber (to see her) he found her supplied with sustenance. He said: "O Mariyam, whence comes this to you?" She said: "from Allah, for Allah provides sustenance to whom he pleases without Measure."
(3:37)

Zakariya's Off-spring

Zakariya ﷺ had no children and he was quite worried about the fact that his relatives, his kindred were not suited for the service of Bani Israel in guiding them towards *Hidayat*. Thus he had the desire that if only Allah would great him a pious son then he would feel at ease. However he had already reached a ripe old age and his wife was barren. Therefor he used to pray to Allah earnestly:

"Behold he [Zakariya ﷺ] cried to his Lord in secret,

Praying: "O My Lord, weak indeed are my bones and the hair of my head glistens with grey: But never have I been unblest, O my Lord many prayer to you. Now I fear what my relatives and colleagues will do after me. But my wife is barren so give me an heir from yourself.

One that will truly represent me and represent the prosterity of Yakoob ﷺ. And make him, O my Lord, one with whom you are well-pleased. (His prayer was answered) "O Zakariya, we give you good news of a son. His name shall be Yahiya. On none by that name have we conferred distinction before."

He said:

"O My Lord, how shall I have a son? when my wife is barren and I have grown quite decrepit it from old age?"

He said: "So (it will be) the Lord says: "That is easy for Me I did indeed create you before when you had been nothing.

Zakairya ﷺ said:

"O My Lord, Give me a sign."

(The answer was) "Your sign shall be that you shall speak to no man for three nights although you are not dumb.

So Zakariya came out to his people from his chamber.

He told them by signs to celebrate Allah's praises. In the morning and the evening."

(19:2—11)

In *Surah Ambiyaa* we read:

"And remember Zakariya ﷺ when he cried to his Lord:

"O My Lord, leave me not without off-spring, though thou are the best of inheritors. So we lessened to him and granted him Yahya ﷺ. We cared his wife's barrenness for him. These there were very quick in emulation in good works. They used to call on us with love and reverence and humble themselves before us.

(21:89—90)

And in *Surah Al-Imraan* we read:

"There did Zakariya ~~صلى الله عليه وسلم~~ pray to his Lord, saying,
"O My Lord, Grant unto me from you progeny
that is pure. For you are.

He that hears prayer.

While he was standing in prayer in his chamber,
The Angels called out to him: "Allah gives you
glad findings of Yahya ~~صلى الله عليه وسلم~~, witnessing the
truth of a word from Allah and be (besides) noble
chase and a prophet.

Of the goodly company of the righteous.

He said: "O My Lord, how shall I have a son,
seeing I am very old And my wife is barren?"

"Thus" was the answer "does Allah accomplish
what He wills."

He said: "O My Lord, give me a sign."

"Thy Sign" was the answer "shall be that you shall
speak to no man for three days but with signals.

Then celebrate the praises of your Lord again
and again And glorify Him in the evening and
the morning. (3:38—41)

Point of Tafsser

Regarding the events of Hazrat Zakariya (*Alaihis Salām*)'s life the most important point in the verse wherein he is informed not to talk to people by word of month for three days. This is to as a sign from Allah that he should only converse with them by means of signs. According to Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharvy this means that in spite of these being no bodily impediments and his health being complete, yet for three days there was going to be hindrance in his tongue. The *Saalih*

predecessors are also agreed that he was not going to fast from speech during that time. And no one says that he was going to become dumb during that period.

The Death of Zakariya عليه السلام

With regard to the martyrdom of Hazrat Yahya عليه السلام the *Ulama* of history and biography are divided as to whether Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام had a natural death or whether he was also martyred. Two types of stories are told and strangely enough both reports are supposed to emanate from one person—Wahb bin Munabbah.

According one report by Wahb bin Monabbah it is said that when the Jews had already killed Hazrat Yahya عليه السلام, they turned towards Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام with the intention of killing him too? When Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام saw this he fled from them. Ahead of him was a big tree and he entered into a crevice of the tree. The Jews followed him. They tried to force him to come out of the crevice, by shooting arrows in his direction. When the arrow started reaching him Allah sent revelation to him: "If you are going to complain of their treatment of you, then I shall destroy this whole earth but if you are going to be patient and steadfast then I will refrain from sending down My wrath and anger over them."

Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام chose to have patience and bore their persecution without any complaints. The Jews cut down the tree and split it into two parts and with that they also split Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام into two, killing him. The other report says that they did shoot arrows but Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام was not killed he later died a natural death.

However the well-known story is that the Jews did in fact kill him. As for how that happened and where, the best seems to say: Allah knows best.

Hazrat Yahiya ﷺ

Hazrat Yahiya ﷺ is mentioned in these same *Surah* of the Qur'ān wherein his illustrious father is mentioned and in these same prayers wherein his father prayed for his coming. For example:

"O Zakariya! We give you good news of a son
His name shall be Yahiya. On none by that name
have we conferred distinction before." (19:07)

The Birth of Hazrat Yahiya ﷺ

Regarding the birth of Hazrat Yahiya ﷺ it is known that he was about six months older than Hazrat Esa ﷺ. It is also known that when Zakariya ﷺ made *Du'a* for him he also asked that he shall be a pious offspring. The Qur'ān says that Allah accepted this *Du'a* and as such Hazrat Yahiya ﷺ was a very pious and righteous person. He never married and neither did any thought of committing sin ever pass over his mind and like his father he was also one of Allah's chosen prophets. Already in his childhood Allah endowed him with knowledge and wisdom. His most excellent duty was that he gave the good news of the coming of Nabi Esa ﷺ and he already prepared the ground with spreading guidance. The Qur'ān states:

"While he was standing in prayer in the chamber,

The Angels called unto him: "Allah gives to you glad tidings of Yahiya ؑ witnessing the truth of a word from Allah and noble, chaste and a prophet of the company of the righteous."

(3:39)

Points of Tafseer

(Here Hazrat Yahiya ؑ has been called 'Sayed'.)

1. In the biographic descriptions at this point the word 'Sayed' has been given various interpretations e.g. soft hasted, a Knower, a scholar of jurisprudence, a leader of men in worldly and spiritual affairs, "nobleman, god-fearing, well-beloved by Allah, and chosen by Allah because this last meaning is one which included all the other meanings. Hence that is the meaning taken here. (Ibn Katheer Vol. 2, p. 361)
2. Similarly Hazrat Yahiya ؑ has also been described as being 'Hasoor', i.e. one who does not even go near to women and is safe from all kinds of sins and over whose heart not even the thought of sin passes. It is one who has full control over his 'Nafs' and keeps all passionate desires away from him.

In our opinion all these descriptions are ways of describing the same thing because etymologically 'Hasr' means to prevent and to prohibit and the word 'Hasoor' is the exaggerated form thereof. So in the above verse it means that he is one who stops the desires from every place where it should be stopped. Yahiya ؑ is the one described as Hasoor and as such all the meanings of the word fit him.

In this task the righteous servants of Allah have always had two ways of acting. Firstly there was the way of withdrawing from those evil and absteaction, where through

strenuous spiritual exercises efforts are made to suppress the *Nafs* and to annihilate the self. In the life of Nabi Esa ﷺ this is the way chosen, but in the case of Yahiya ﷺ Allah granted to him this quality without spiritual exercises. This was put into him from the very beginning. There was not even a chance of him committing a sin.

3. Although the first of these two ways is in itself praiseworthy, it is a way of life which is not totally suitable for man's nature and for the social life of men. Hence the prophets who chose that type of life did so for certain special reasons of the times, especially when their mission was limited to special peoples. But for the sake of congregational life the natural demand was mostly for the second method. For this reason the personal teaching of Rasulullah ﷺ and his own individual actions confirm this second method, especially since his mission was to all the world's people therefore his natural religion this should be uppermost. Hence in various faces of life Rasulullah ﷺ drew attention towards it that it is better to remain involved with worldly affairs and carry out your deen while avoiding sin than to become secluded in mountains, cares and the deserts.

Qur'ân states:

"(To Yahiya came the command): O Yahiya take hold of the Book with might and we gave him wisdom as a youth.

And pity (for all creatures) as from us and purity He was devout.

And Kind to his parents and he was not over bearing rebellious."

So peace be upon him the day he was born,
The day that he dies and the day he will be raised
up to life." (19:12—15)

In these verses it says: "And we gave him knowledge and wisdom as a youth." According to a *Hadith* quoted by Ibn Katheer from Abdullah bin Mubarak this means Yahiya ؑ in his youth already was endowed with virtue and knowledge. Those who take this verse to mean that Yahiya ؑ was made a prophet in his childhood already have made a mistake, because the office of prophethood is a very high and important office and to give it to someone in his childhood is completely against reason and also against anything quoted from our predecessors.

4. In these verses a prayer is expressed of peace and safety. These three times are three very serious and delicate times. Firstly, the time of birth i.e., the time of emerging from the mother's womb into this world. Secondly, the time of death i.e., the time of leaving this world into the *Barzakh*, and thirdly, the time of being raised up in the time of leaving the *Barzakh* for the *Aakhirat* to receive either reward or punishment. Hence the person who has received the good news of safety and peace for these three times receives the happiness and success of both worlds.

Conveying the Message

According to an authentic *Hadith* Rasulullah ؐ said:

"Allah command Yahiya ؑ bin Zakariya ؑ with five things which he should carry out and conveying to Bani Israel. Therefore he called Bani Israel together in Baitul Muqaddas and when the Mosque was full he said to them: "Allah has

ordered me to do five things that I should myself carry them out and convey them to you. The five things are the following:

Firstly, worship none except Allah and associate no one unto him. Associating anyone unto Him is like the slave of one of you whom the Master has bought with his own money and now the slave has adopted this action that whatever he earns he grants to another. Now tell me, will anyone of you like that his slave should do that. So understand that when Allah has created you, grants you sustenance, you should only worship Him and not associate anyone unto Him.

Secondly, Say your prayers with sincerity and earnestly for when in your prayers you are directed at Him alone, then Allah will continue to be directed in your direction with pleasure and mercy.

Thirdly, fast because the example of a fasting person is like him who sits among a congregation with a bag filled with Musk, because the fragrance of musk will permeate his companions. And do not pay attention to the smell emanating from the mouth of a fasting person is cleaner than the fragrance of musk.

Fourthly, take out charity from your wealth and possessions because the giver of charity is like that person whom his enemies have captured is like that person whom his enemies have captured suddenly and whose hands have been tied to his neck as they lead him to the place of execution and in that hopeless state he says:

"Can I present money to save myself. When he finds a positive answer to his request he offers all his wealth."

Fifthly, Abundantly remember Allah by night and by day because such a person is like the one fleeing from an

enemy with the enemy on his heels and having fled he enters into a strong fortress for refuge to be safe from the enemy. Because surely, to be safe from man's enemy, '*Shaitan*' is to enter into an impregnable fortress."

There upon Rasulullah  turned towards the *Sahabah* and said: "I also command you to follow five such things which Allah has commanded me; namely, to hold fast onto the congregation, to listen and obey your leader, to migrate and to perform *Jihad* in the path of Allah. Whenever has moved outside the congregation even one step, has surely taken the yoke of Islām from his neck.

Hence hold onto the congregation. And whosoever calls towards the things of the *Jahiliyya* has made *Jahannam* his abode. Sayeduna Haarith Ashtomy  says, "Some one asked: "O Messenger of Allah! Is it so even if that person is a regular in *Salah* and *fasting*."

Rasulullah  replied: "Yes, even if he is a regular performer of *Salah* and *fasting* and believes that: I am a Muslim still will his punishment be *Jahannam*."

(*Al-Bidaya wal-Nihayah*, Vol. 2, page 52)

Ibn Asakir  has quoted some reports by Wahb bin Munabba  that Hazrat had such fear for Allah that he was almost always crying so that on his checks there were signs of the tears flowing. Therefore when once his father searched for him in the desert and found him, he said to him:

"O My Son We are worried about you, searching for you, while you are here crying and lamenting."

Yahya  replied:

"You have informed us that between *Jannat* and *Jahannam* there is a desolate plain which no

one will be able to cross without the shedding of tears out of fear for Allah and without that one will not reach *Jannat*." When Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام heard this he also started crying.

(*Al-Bidayah wal-Nihayah*)

The Story of His Martyrdom

When Yahiya عليه السلام began to call people to the *Deen*, he also told them that after him a bigger and more illustrious prophet was going to appear, the Jews started bearing hatred and enmity towards him. They could not tolerate his preaching and one day they gathered around him and asked him: "Are you the 'Massiah?" He replied: "No" Then they said to him: "Are you that prophet?" He replied: "No" Then they asked him: 'Are you Eliah عليه السلام, the prophet?" He replied: "No" Then they all asked him: "Then, who are you? Who preach to us like this and call thus?" He replied: "I am the voice of him who calls in the desert, who has been raised up for the truth."

Hearing this the Jews rose up in anger and in the end killed him.

The Place of Martyrdom

Regarding the place of his martyrdom there is no certain evidence us to where it happened. But this is certain that the Jews were the killers. In the Qur'ān in various places there is mention of the Jews' Killing of the Prophets (*Alaihis Salām*).

The Night of Maeraaj

In Bukhari's, *Kitabul Ambiyaa*, Imam Bukhari only mentioned a piece of the *Hadith* of the Maeraaj in which is stated that Rasulullah ﷺ met him in the second heaven: The *Hadith* states:

Thus when I reached the second heaven I saw Yahiya ؑ and Esa ؑ; they are both cousins. Jibrael ؑ said to me: "These are Yahiya and Esa (*Alaihimus Salām*) Great them:

I greeted them and they both answered me greeting back. They both said: "May your name be blessed! O righteous brother and pious prophet.

Warnings and Lessons

1. There Cannot be anyone more wretched and unfortunate then that person who kills such a saintly personality who neither troubles him nor tries to take away his wealth and possessions. In fact without asking for any payment he strives to rectify lives and serves them in their character building, their actions and there beliefs in such a manner that it is to their benefit in this world and the hereafter.
2. Though Allah's grace an person should never give up hope and even if at times he prays to Allah with sincerity and his aim is not reached it does not mean that Allah has turned away from him. Some times Allah in His Knowledge knows that certain things for which a man prays can be harmful to him, which of course that person does not know due to his limited knowledge. And sometimes for the sake of the general benefit of all it is required that a person's individual benefit should be postponed.

In any case to give up hope for Allah's grace and bounty is definitely not a praiseworthy thing:

"Do not despair of the Mercy of Allah. Verily only such ones give up hope for the Mercy of Allah, who are non-believers." (12:87)

QASASUL AMBIYAA

STORIES OF THE PROPHETS

Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy (Rah.)



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Qasasul Ambiyaa

(Stories of the Prophets)

By: Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy (Ra)

Translated by: Maulana Yusuf Karaan



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Tel.: +91-11-2695 6832 & 085888 33786

Fax: +91-11-6617 3545 Email: sales@idara.co

Online Store: www.idarastore.com

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Shop 6, Nizamia Complex, Gali Gadrian, Hazrat Nizamuddin
New Delhi-110013 (India) Tel.: 085888 44786

Qasasul Ambiyaa

The Holy Qur'ān does not relate historical facts merely for the sake of telling a story which is of historical value. Its main aim in relating happenings is to draw attention to the results, conclusions and deductions from these incidents so that they become a source of guidance for men and prove to be lessons for them that appeal to their minds and emotions that from these historical events, lessons should be derived. These lessons should convince them that the existence of Allah is an undeniable fact and that His Mighty Hand is playing a major role in the affairs of men. It should also bring to their notice that to follow the stipulations of His deen brings success and leads to salvation and is the way towards all progress. That is what Islām—the natural religion—is about.

From: Qasasul Qur'ān

Preface

The most authentic and comprehensive work of Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy, *Qasasul Qur'ān* needs no introduction. However, the Manner in which our friend Sayed Tanzeem Hussain Saheb has brought forth an abridged version of a voluminous and bulky work he has undoubtedly, fulfilled one of the needs of this time. He has adopted such a method of abridgement whereby not only has he retained and mentioned every important fact in the lives of the Holy Prophets (*Alaihimus Salām*) and other saintly personalities, which are of lessons to men, but also discussed in brought outline some other important matters. It is hoped that with Allah's grace, those persons who are occupied and busy at all times, will be able to derive adequate benefit from this work.

The great effort of Sayed Tanzeem Hussain in this old age of his is really something praiseworthy. May Allah reward him well for this great effort.

Qari Sayed Rasheedul-Hasan Hussainy Nadwi

Imam and Khateeb

Jama Masjid, New Town

Allamah Binori Town, Karachi

P5 Muharram, 1308 Hijri

Publisher's Foreword

The respected personality of Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy is one of the most eminent Ulama of the Indo-Pak Sub-Continent. His most approved and well-known book, *Qasasul-Qur'ān* is considered to be a unique publication on this subject. The point that distinguishes it from other similar books is the fact that after every story, Maulana has made use of deep thought and reflection to present to the readers the lessons and points of guidance from the related episodes. Thus for the teachers and lecturers at *Deeni Madressas* and for preachers in mosques and students of deen the study and perusal of this book is of utmost benefit.

The original book appeared in four volumes with over 1800 pages of subject matter. Sayed Tanzeem Hussain Saheb has brought forth an abridged version there of in only 600 pages and this has been met with a verdict of approval from all academic circles, especially by virtue of the fact that he has fulfilled one of the most pressing needs of the time and by leaving aside unimportant discussions have given the busy and occupied ones also a chance to benefit from these work. May Allah reward him well.

Author's Foreword

All praise be to Allah who has guided us with the Holy Book and revealed to us the Qur'ān in a clear Arabic language and in it. He related the best of stories as an admonition and a reminder for the believers. And May peace and blessings be upon the Most truthful and trustworthy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, the messenger of Allah and seal of all the Prophets and upon his offspring, and companions who were all of them guiding stars for all the righteous ones.

Among the inimitable ways in which Allah has chosen for the sake of the guidance of men, is this that attention is drawn to the good and bad deeds of nations and the resultant fruits of such deeds of which they are reminded so that those deeds may be a lesson for men. For this reason those stories are not being related in a style as is generally done in history. The major aim is to convey the truth and to invite to Allah and with this in mind attention is only drawn to those aspects which furthers this objective. For this reason there is constant repetition so that these events can sink into the hearts and minds of listeners and they become attentive towards them. This sinking in and attentiveness can only be achieved if the same event is repeated in various ways and styles whereby sleeping faculties are woken up.

The Qur'ānic stories and events deal mostly with previous nations and the Messengers of Allah (*Alaihimus*

Salām) who were sent to them and bit by bit other matters also become included there-in, mostly dealing with the arguments over good and bad and the battles between the friends of Allah and the friends of *Shaitan*, which in itself proves to be a great lesson and admonishment for me.

But, leaving others aside, there are today so few Muslims who derive benefit from Allah's last and perfect law-book, the Qur'ān, to fill our hearts with *Iman* and *Yaqeen*. After all it is Allah's law and we are commanded to implement its orders in our lives, Moreover we are required to ponder over its meanings as this Qur'ān is the means forwards acquiring success and salvation in both this world and the here after.

At the time of the Revelation of the Qur'ān, the Messenger of Allah became so distressed and defected at the enmity and opposition of the polytheists that he raised this complaint to Allah:

(5:25—30)

However, in this 15th century, if we should examine our hearts, we will find that in spite of our claims to be Muslims and believing the Qur'ān to be the word of Allah, how few are who have made this word of Allah the pattern for their lives and the model on which to base their lives, who read and recited with this aim in mind?

It was my aim, seeing this condition of my people and myself, to translate this great source of admonition into Urdu so that by presenting the translated version, the hearts of people will automatically become drawn to the original i.e., the Qur'ān and thereby acquire everlasting happiness.

In spite of my simple style of writing, care has been taken to confine myself to a few special points.

- (a) In this book the basis for all the stories is the Holy Qur'ān and the authentic *Hadith* and these have been further elucidated with historical facts.
- (b) Where there appears any contradiction or differences in the stories as told in the old testament and the Qur'ān, then with clear arguments an effort has been made either to reconcile the versions or with clear arguments to prove the truth as is expounded in the Qur'ān.
- (c) An effort has been made to point out the nonsensical Israili stories and where there have been nonsensical objections from enemies, these have in the light of the true facts been made clear for what they are.
- (d) In some special places there have been introduced some discussions on matters of disputes in *Tafseer* and *Hadith* and after discussing these the views of the saintly elders have been mentioned as a solution.
- (e) The facts concerning every Prophet ﷺ and in which chapter of the Qur'ān they are mentioned, has been gathered in one place.
- (f) Lastly, together with all the above points, a special heading of "Results and lessons", is introduced, giving the actual objective of this book and its main purpose viz., admonition and warning. Special attention is drawn to this aspect.

Servant of the Millat

Muhammad Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy

22 Rajab, 1360 Hijri

Translator's Foreword

For me as the translator of this book by Maulana Hifzur Rahman is a great honour. Throughout my student days in Darul Uloom Deoband in India, Maulana Hifzur Rahman or as we know him then as the *Mujahid-e-Millat* was one of the most respected leaders of the Muslim community. We used to flock to listen to his most interesting lectures. And as the general secretary of the *Jamiatul-Ulama*, and a M.P. he was also a great 'Alim (scholar) as can be gauged from this book *Qasasul Ambiya* (Tales of the Prophets) which entailed great research. I can remember whenever the students were confronted with any problem in the lives of any of the prophets, they always took refuge in Maulana's book for answers. I took upon it as a great honour in being in some small manner associated with Maulana's scholarship, even though this is an abridged version of the original book. But I must also state that I found great difficulty in translating this book because of the exceptionally high quality of the Urdu language used in the book.

I hope that the English translation of Maulana Hifzur Rahman's scholarly work will also be of great benefit to the English-speaking people. I just hope that I have been able to do justice to the original thoughts of the author.

Yusuf Karaan
Strand, South Africa